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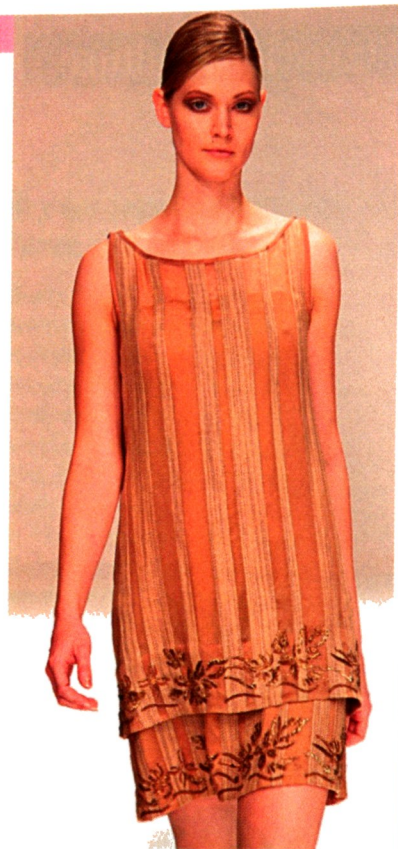


The Howrah boys have developed textiles from handlooms of Bengal with a special weave of linen, cotton and silk with some metallic gold.

"We customise differently; our creations always incorporate ethnic influences."

Chanderi and natural dye experts from Jaipur contributed to her ergonomic look. It is this innovation with the tried and traditional that poses a challenge for designers Rahul Jain and Gunjan Arora of Sirali. "It's never been satisfying to just pick up a fabric and embellish it. In Indian fashion it is believed that embroidery makes couture. But we believe that rich material and yarn can also make a fabric priceless," says Arora. The result was a unique non-woven fabric, called art fabric, where cotton, silk and other yarns are held

and fused together, sans any weaving. "We use a mechanical process of stitching different coloured threads in place with a transparent, heat-resistant nylon thread that is



strong but doesn't affect the desired colouration," explains Arora. The Sirali designers believe it is important to know your basics and then innovate. "Tap what has already been done and then prove your mettle by innovating," says Gunjan. True to their word, Gunjan and Rahul have used the art fabric to create unique art pieces, besides garments, and earned themselves an identity as textile artists.

Each of these designers has a purpose behind their passion. Having worked closely with weavers in Bhagalpur and *bandhini* artisans in Bhuj, Rahul Mishra says, "Such projects expose the craft to an international audience and also create employment by giving impetus to manual labour. We believe craft is not

Deepti Toor

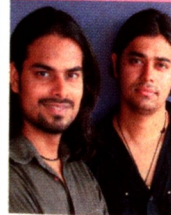


The Ahmedabad-based designer has created papier mache fabrics with jute and employed tribal Warli prints in her design.

"Each design was uniquely crafted. The idea is to create textiles with design."



Rahul & Firdos



The Ahmedabad-based duo revived the '*bandhini*', the traditional textile of Bhuj, Kutch, with newer silhouettes and shorter lengths.

"We have preserved the craft by giving it a new expression."

required if it doesn't serve craftspeople." The objective for Shyamal & Bhumika is clear as well. "We feel our work should be meaningful. Handwoven textiles provide large scale employment, are eco-friendly, don't use electricity, their production doesn't lead to any sort of pollution and they are easy on the skin. The positives of using traditional textiles are unlimited," says Shyamal.

It is these positives that are encouraging designers like Rahul & Firdos to develop houndstooth and tweed weaves on Bhagalpur's looms. Even as Chauhan perseveres to innovate with fabric and sets up a knitwear unit in Bhagalpur, Shyamal & Bhumika are supporting an organisation which rears silk worms on oak trees to prevent deforestation. With good fashion comes great responsibility.